Using Appropriate Tone

Concept

Tone is the attitude your wording conveys. Match the level of formality to your audience, purpose and situation.

Audience

A friend, teacher and formal public audience may expect different registers.

Purpose

A request, reflection and argument call for different choices.

Register

The handout uses five levels: very informal, informal, formal, more formal and highly formal.

Precision

Formal writing can still be clear and direct. Long words do not automatically improve tone.

Consistency

Keep slang, contractions, sentence patterns and address appropriate to the task.

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Example 1 | original model

Revise for a teacher: "Hey, send me that thing ASAP."

Solution / why it works

1. Identify the problem: vague wording and a demanding tone.

2. Revision: Could you please send me the assignment rubric before tomorrow's class?

3. The revision names the item, states a useful time and makes a respectful request.

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Tone scale | adapted from the handout

1

Very informal|A casual exchange with close friends; shared slang may be understood.

2

Informal|Familiar conversation, such as with a parent or guardian.

3

Formal|Clear, respectful language, such as an academic exchange with a teacher.

4

More formal|A carefully worded request to a principal or employer.

5

Highly formal|A formal academic, ceremonial or professional setting.

Use judgment

These are the source's illustrative levels, not fixed rules for every relationship. Consider the actual task and context.

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Practice | your turn

1. Rewrite "That plan is dumb" as a respectful disagreement for a class discussion.

2. Write a request for the same missing file to a friend and to a teacher.

3. Identify three choices that changed the tone.

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Sample answers | check after trying

Writing tasks can have more than one strong answer. Use these models and checks to review your work.

1

I disagree with the plan because it does not explain how the equipment will be shared.

2

Friend: Can you send me the notes? Teacher: Could you please share the notes from Monday's lesson?

3

Look at vocabulary, politeness, detail, contractions and directness.

Source & editing note

Use Appropriate Tone.pdf | 1 supplied pages.

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